The Sūtra of Great Auspiciousness

Mahāmaṅgalasūtra · Toh 43 · Derge Kangyur
བཀ་བྲཀྲིས་ཆེན་པའོ་མདོ།

The Sūtra of Great Auspiciousness, known in Sanskrit as the Mahāmaṅgala Sūtra and in Tibetan as the Bkra shis chen po'i mdo, is a short discourse in which the Buddha explains what truly constitutes auspiciousness. Its setting is the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī, in the park of Anāthapiṇḍada. There, in the night, a host of gods illuminates the grove with many-colored light, approaches the Buddha, and asks him in verse to resolve their doubts and describe the supreme auspiciousness. The Buddha answers in verse, presenting genuine good fortune as a matter of ethical conduct, wise associations, and spiritual practice rather than omens or rituals. This text is Toh 43 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the sūtras, the discourses attributed to the Buddha.

In the language of India: mahāmaṃgala sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Sūtra of Great Auspiciousness.

I prostrate with reverence to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada. Then, in the night, many gods all at once lit up the Jeta Grove with lights of many different colors. They went to where the Blessed One was staying, and when they had arrived, they bowed to the Blessed One and sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, those gods put their request to the Blessed One in many verses:

"Many gods and humans
Have pondered what is auspicious.
Doubts have arisen about what is auspicious.
Please tell us the supreme auspiciousness."

The God of gods (the Buddha) declared:
"What utterly destroys all evil
And serves to benefit the whole world,
Those auspicious things I shall explain to you.

Do not associate with fools;
Associate with the wise;
Honor those worthy of honor in return.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Through merit made in the past,
To dwell in a suitable land,
And to make the highest aspiration for oneself:
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Truth, the skills of the hands,
Training well in the practice of discipline,
And words that are well spoken:
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Serve and honor father and mother;
Care for children and wife;
Do not do what is improper.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Generosity, conduct in keeping with the Dharma,
And caring for one's relatives;
Do not do blameworthy deeds.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Give up delight in evil;
Completely avoid drinking alcohol;
To be heedful in the Dharma:
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Show respect to guests and teachers;
Know what has been done for you, and show respect;
Listen to the Dharma at the proper time.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Be patient with harsh words;
Go to see the renunciants (śramaṇas);
At the proper time hold discussion of the Dharma.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Practice austerity and pure conduct;
See the truths of the noble ones;
Directly realize nirvāṇa.
This is the supreme auspiciousness.

When touched by the worldly conditions,
To keep the mind from wavering,
To be patient, free of sorrow and discontent:

This is the supreme auspiciousness.

Those who act in the way thus explained
Are victorious everywhere
And go everywhere in peace.
For them this is the supreme auspiciousness."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those gods rejoiced in praise of what the Blessed One had taught.

The Sūtra of Great Auspiciousness is complete.

By the power of the merit of this,
Until I attain buddhahood,
May the wisdom of Mahauṣadha,
The wealth of Jotika the rich,
And the generosity of Viśvantara
Be mine in birth after birth.

The Noble Sūtra of Turning the Wheel of Dharma, the Explanation of the Introduction to the Jātakas, the Sūtra of the Palace of Alakāvatī, the Sūtra of the Great Assembly, the Sūtra on Loving-Kindness, the Sūtra on Meditating on Loving-Kindness, the Sūtra Teaching the Benefits of the Five Precepts, the Sūtra of the Venerable Girimānanda, the Sūtra on Taming the Nāga Kings Nanda and Upananda, the Sūtra of the Elder Mahākāśyapa, the Sūtra of the Sun, the Sūtra of the Moon, and the Sūtra of Great Auspiciousness: these thirteen sūtras were commissioned by the Zhalu lord Kushang Drakpa Gyaltsen, the Wensha. He was the master of the temple of the noble Self-Arisen Lokeśvara at Tsang Nyangro Tsongdu Gurmo, among the snow mountains of Tibet, the land reached by traveling some hundred yojanas northeast of Vajrāsana, the seat of awakening in the noble land at the center of Jambudvīpa. He was especially devoted to the teaching of the Buddha, the Blessed One, and had attained the supreme rank of lordship over great wealth and dominion.

At his command, the learned translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, translated, edited and finalized them at the great monastery of glorious Tharpa Ling, the seat of those who speak two languages, working with the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī. Ānandaśrī was a native of Siṃhala, the land reached by traveling some six hundred yojanas south of Vajrāsana, the seat of awakening. Born into a brahmin family, he had properly gone forth and received full

ordination, and his mind was thoroughly trained in the three baskets of scripture.

Here is contained volume Ka of the Avataṃsaka.

Translator's Notes

• This sūtra corresponds to the Pāli Mahāmaṅgala Sutta, translated into Tibetan from a Sinhalese source. Several lines reflect the Tibetan translator's reading of the Pāli. "Truth" probably stands for Pāli bahusacca, "learning," read as sacca, "truth." The line rendered "Show respect to guests and teachers" is uncertain: the Tibetan glo bur, literally "sudden, adventitious," is taken here to mean those who arrive unannounced, that is, guests. "When touched by the worldly conditions" translates a Tibetan that literally says "when asked about"; this follows the Pāli phuṭṭha, "touched." "Jotika" for "Ötso the rich" is a tentative identification with the proverbially wealthy Jotika of the Pāli tradition. "Wensha" is taken to be a Yuan-court official title held by the Zhalu lords, apparently Chinese yuanshi, "commissioner." The final line is the opening heading of the following volume in the Kangyur.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.